BearHacks

BearHacks 2026 Judges Guide

Thank you for volunteering your time to serve as a judge for BearHacks 2026! Your contribution is crucial to the success of our event and the experience of our participants. We truly appreciate you joining us for this exciting day!

Please reserve the event on your calendar using this link:
https://calendar.app.google/m8PGZfqseVuccGWk6

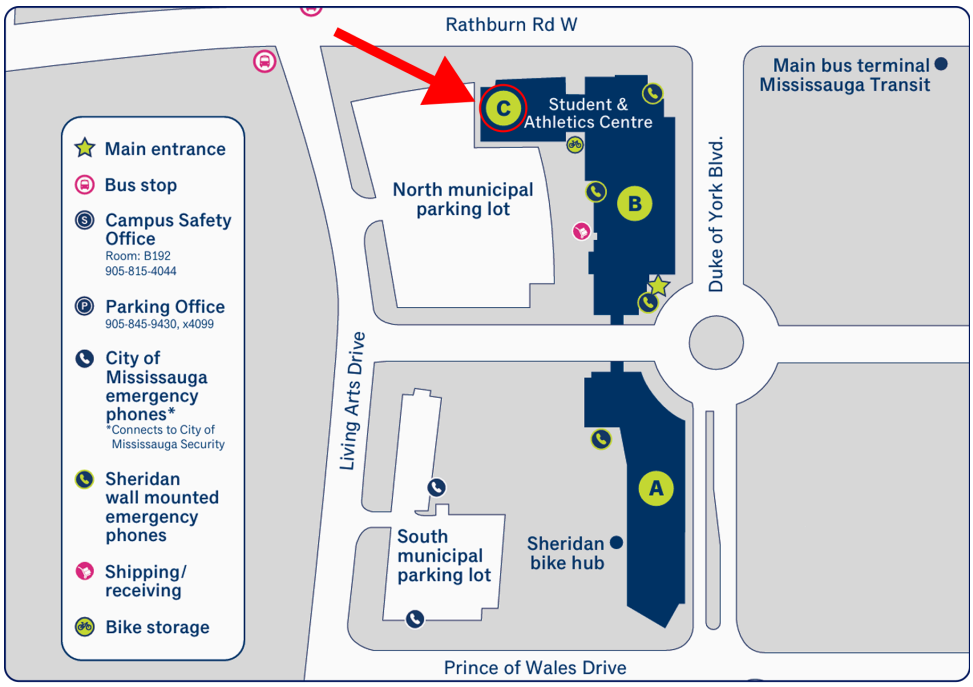
Event Details & Agenda

Name	**BearHacks 2026**
Location	Sheridan College Hazel McCallion Campus 4180 Duke of York Blvd, Mississauga, ON L5B 0H7
Date	Sunday, April 26th, 2026
Format	In-Person

Judges Arrival Time	9:00 AM
Judges Briefing Presentation	9:30 AM - 10:00 AM
Project Demos	11:00 AM - 12:00 PM
Lunch Time	12:30 PM - 2:00 PM
Judges Deliberation	1:00 PM - 3:00 PM
Closing Ceremony	3:30 PM - 4:00 PM

Directions & Contact Info

The event is hosted entirely in the C-Wing, and the main judging room will be located in the **2nd Floor, Room C202**. Here is a map of the venue:



We will be using **Discord** for all communications. Please create an account if you haven't yet, then join our server here: https://discord.gg/8anEkjqEGp

If you have any questions or require assistance on the day of the event, please contact:

Name	Phone Number	Email
Taimoor Aleem	(416) 827-0507	taimooraleem01@gmail.com
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Aleks Bursac	(647) 568-2535	aleksbrsc@gmail.com

We look forward to seeing you at the event!

Rundown

9:30 AM - 10:00 AM | Judge Briefing Presentation
A short presentation explaining the judging process, the rubric, and more specific details. This will be held in Room C202, 2nd floor in Building C.

11:00 AM - 12:00 PM | Project Demos/Judging
Teams will be at their tables ready to present their projects. Judges will be assigned table numbers to visit, then will evaluate projects based on the given rubric. Please ensure you keep track of time (3 minutes demo, 2 minutes Q&A) and try to shortlist projects you think should be considered for a prize.

12:30 PM | Lunch
A complimentary lunch will be provided for all judges and participants.

1:00 PM - 3:00 PM | Deliberation
Judges will reconvene back to Room C202 to discuss the scores and finalize the winners for each prize track. Please ensure you have submitted all scores before 1:00 PM, as they are used to shortlist winning projects.

Judging Criteria

Judges will evaluate projects based on the following criteria. The general judging rubric is on the next page, but please note there are prize tracks beyond 1st-3rd place with more specific criteria which will be explained during the briefing.

You will receive a scoring sheet for all tracks during the briefing.

Preliminary Theme Check
Pass or Fail — Does the project align with the theme?

Execution (40%)
How technically / visually impressive is it? Is the project complete? Is it built with a positive user experience in mind?

Creativity & Originality (20%)
Is it new and exciting? Does it push the boundaries for a hackathon project?

Impact (20%)
Does it solve a real problem? Does it have real-world value?

Presentation (20%)
Was the project explained clearly? Was the demo video interesting, persuasive, and high quality?

Prize Tracks

These are the prize tracks that all judges will need to keep in mind:

- *Best Use of Google Cloud Vision API*
- *Best Use of ElevenLabs*
- *Best Hardware Hack*
- *Best UI/UX Design (we have design judges specifically for this track)*
- *Best Demo Video*
- *Most Fun Project*

Judging Rubric

	Excellent	Strong	Developing	Weak	*Points*
Execution	***33 – 40*** Runs cleanly end-to-end. UI/UX is intuitive without explanation. Well-scoped, cohesive stack, polished and stable product. Great MVP!	***25 – 32*** Core flow is reliable but has minor friction. UI is mostly clear. Rough edges, but nothing is terribly broken. Solid MVP.	***17 – 23*** Core flow works on happy path. Edge cases break or stall flow. UI needs explanation. Doesn't seem like a finished product.	***0 – 16*** Demo fails or is partially simulated. UI/UX is poor or unusable. The tech doesn't solve the problem.	/40
Creativity & Orginality	***17 – 20*** Highly creative project or new idea not seen before. Very distinct from common hackathon patterns.	***14 – 16*** Familiar problem with a clear twist, or an underexplored problem. At least one unique feature or insight.	***10 – 13*** Standard category (chatbot, wrapper). Differentiation is small or cosmetic. Similar to many existing projects.	***0 – 9*** Generic/unoriginal. Replicates common projects. Nothing special in the idea.	/20
Impact	***17 – 20*** Specific user and context defined. Clear pain point with reasoning. Solution measurably improves current state. Feasible path to real users or deployment.	***14 – 16*** Plausible user and use case. Value is clear but not validated. Would require iteration to be practical.	***10 – 13*** Vague or unclear user need. Benefit is unclear. Competes with strong existing solutions.	***0 – 9*** No clear user or need. Problem is trivial or artificial. No realistic use beyond demo.	/20
Presentation	***17 – 20*** Problem, user, and solution clear in the first minute. Demo supports claims directly. Answers are direct and specific.	***14 – 16*** Clear overall but slightly slow or uneven. Demo works but rough edges. Some gaps in answers.	***10 – 13*** Key points delayed or unclear. Demo rushed or inconsistent. Answers are vague. Setup eats time.	***0 – 9*** Cannot clearly explain problem or solution. Demo confuses/contradicts pitch. Can't answer basic questions.	/20

“Best UI/UX Design” Judging Criteria 🎨

User Experience (40%)

Is the product intuitive, easy, and satisfying to use?

- Core flow is obvious without explanation
- Navigation is clear and predictable
- Interactions feel smooth and responsive
- Minimal friction or confusion

Visual Design (25%)

Is the product intuitive, easy, and satisfying to use?

- Consistent use of colors, fonts, and spacing
- Clear visual hierarchy and emphasis
- Important actions stand out
- Professional and intentional look

Problem Fit (20%)

Does it solve a real, defined user problem?

- Target user and need are clear
- Features directly support the problem
- No unnecessary screens or actions
- Solution is practical and relevant

Presentation (15%)

Is the design and thinking clearly communicated?

- Problem and solution explained quickly
- Design decisions are justified
- Demo supports the story
- Delivery is clear and structured